tough action was taken.
A. We arrested the accused in the Kanhaiya Lal case within two hours after which the NIA [National Investigation Agency] took over. It was the BJP officebearers who got the accused released before this murder when the cops had detained them in another case. They were even garlanded.

Q. You have accused the Centre of not declaring the Eastern River Canal Project a national project. The Centre alleges your proposal is not cost-effective.
A. The ERCP was the Vasundhara Raje government's project. The PM had given assurances. But after we came to power, the Centre rejected it on various pretexts. People in 13 districts who could have benefited from this canal project to provide water for drinking and irrigation are very upset. I sanctioned Rs 14,000 crore to start work on it. So, people can see who cares for them.

Q. The conflict with Sachin Pilot negatively affected your government's image. Is there unity now and has a decision been taken on who will be the next CM?
A. I have read some of his (Sachin) interviews, which are balanced. We gave tickets based on surveys and the winnability criteria, rising above factionalism. The Congress never announces a CM candidate and takes a call after discussing it with MLAs and judging the people's demands.

Q. For the past 30 years, no incumbent government has been re-elected in Rajasthan. Do you feel confident that you will return?
A. Kerala re-elected its government for the first time in 40 years mainly because of its Covid management. We have done a lot more than that. If educated voters can acknowledge it there, I have hope that our voters will also see the difference that we have made in Rajasthan. ■

INTERVIEW: GAJENDRA SHEKHAWAT

'WE'RE WAY AHEAD IN THE RACE'

UNION MINISTER GAJENDRA SHEKHAWAT GIVES THE OPPOSITION BJP'S TAKE IN WHAT IS PROVING TO BE A CLOSELY FOUGHT CAMPAIGN. EXCERPTS:

Q. The BJP seems to have enlisted a surfeit of leaders in Rajasthan. Isn't it better to have a CM face?
A. It does help to have a CM face, but then it may also result in intra-party rivalry. We will win Rajasthan comfortably. It is not just anti-incumbency against the Ashok Gehlot government, but the people want the BJP back in power. The voters feel if PM Modi can do it for India, his government can do so much for Rajasthan. We don't just have an edge, we are way ahead in the race. It is because of the way we planned our campaign a year back, taking out yatras and building on the anti-incumbency.

Q. CM Gehlot says the welfare measures he launched are the Congress's USP this election?
A. The promises he made before the last election have not been fulfilled, nor have any of the big projects been completed. The same is the case with his government's welfare schemes. For instance, if you look at the free smartphones scheme, we found them to be of rather poor quality. And then they have been given to just one-tenth of the population he had promised, and it cost the government a lot more than the actual value. We have convinced the people that it is a scam, and at their cost. It is the same for his other schemes too. All sorts of illegal activities and corruption are happening under the protection of MLAs. That is why there is so much anti-incumbency against Congress MLAs.

Q. The BJP seems to be playing the Hindutva card in Rajasthan...
A. The people are angry over his 'appeasement' moves. The CM led a march of Muslims in Jaipur against the CAA [Citizenship (Amendment) Act]. Then the state intelligence agency failed to prevent stone pelting on a Hindu procession in Karauli and the Muslims accused were let go. He banned Hindu processions on the Covid pretext, but allowed the Popular Front of India (PFI) to hold one. So, people got angry over such appeasement moves and there were riots in retaliation.